

NATURE'S WRATH
Rescuers stand amid the debris at Chooralmala in Wayanad, Jul. 31

AP

Imagine all the rain Delhi gets in a year, packed into just 48 hours, and bucketed down over a small stretch of sloping mountain soil that's already soaked to the brim by torrential Kerala monsoons. When the earth under their feet finally gave way, in the dead of night, two Wayanad villages slipped into oblivion. Mundakkai, and two miles downriver, Chooralmala met this last nightmare of their lives—a horrific cascade of mud, water and death—on July 30. At least 230 people were confirmed dead by July 31 night, but with nearly 200 still missing, that body count looked likely to swell. The worst part is, it was a tragedy foretold. Landslides are a near-endemic phenomenon on the eastern flank of Kerala, where it rises up to the mighty Western Ghats: the state records the highest number in the country, and accounted for 2,239 of the 3,782 landslides between 2015 and 2022, according to the ministry of earth sciences. You can blame it all on nature—if you include human nature, that is.

What happened in Wayanad was a disaster that "we consciously brought upon ourselves", says environmentalist V.S. Vijayan who was part of the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (WGEEP) report drafted by the renowned Madhav Gadgil. The Gadgil report, presented to the Union environment ministry in 2011, was also supposed to be a wake-up call for states that allow rampant constructions on hill slopes without a holistic risk assessment. The report had included the picturesque Vythiri, Mananthavady and Sultan Bathery taluks in Wayanad in the Ecologically Sensitive Zone-1 (ESZ-1) category, denoting the highest grade of sensitivity and thus demanding zero change in land use. Most incriminatingly for the collective Indian political-business overlords, Meppadi in Vythiri taluk, just 2-3 km from Mundakkai and Chooralmala where the worst occurred, sits right there in the report, as one of the 18 ESZs the Gadgil panel identified in Kerala. Far from zero change, the landscape was being ravaged by 'modernity'.

The panel had proposed that quarrying and red category industries (ones with a pollution index score of 60 or above) should not be allowed in ESZ-1. Moreover, in regions where quarrying was permitted, a distance of at least 100 metres had to be maintained from human settlements. However, the state government reduced the distance by half, to 50 metres, says Vijayan. As a result, indiscriminate quarrying, along with mushrooming tourist resorts, have altered Wayanad's topography itself.

Following opposition from several state governments, the Centre rejected the Gadgil report and just a year later appointed a high-level working group, led by former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chairman K. Kasturirangan, presumably to hand it a less onerous set of recommendations. Sure enough, while the Gadgil panel wanted about 75 per cent of the Western Ghats to be notified as ESAs (eco-sensitive areas), the Kasturirangan committee trimmed it to 37 per cent. But even these have yet to be notified, with the states along the Western Ghats resorting to dilatory tactics.